

ent could still go. Narang, whose family sold a plot of land to buy him a gun, had support from Air-India and occasionally the Andhra Pradesh government before the oco committed itself to filling in the gaps.

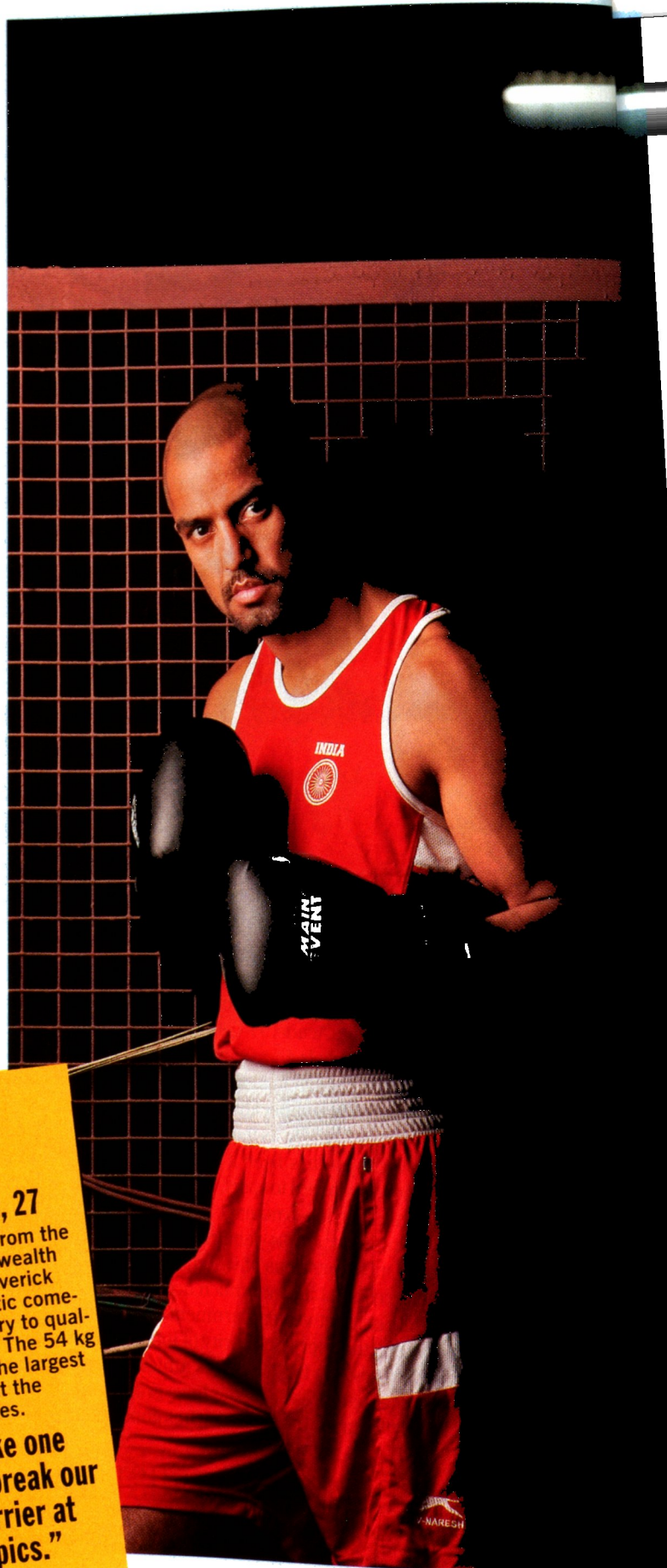
Of the private programmes, the mcr is the most ambitious. It currently supports 32 athletes across seven disciplines: shooting, archery, squash, boxing, badminton, athletics and swimming. Thirteen athletes supported by the mcr will be competing in Beijing, 14 if trap shooter Ronjon Sodhi gets a wild card. Working to get mcr going has been a crash course in Indian sport for its Chief Administrator Manisha Malhotra, who says, "We want to make a difference in athletes' lives—to understand what they need and make it available."

With \$10m to spend and core sports identified, the mcr first discovered that its cheques sent to federations often went unutilised. Malhotra, a former national tennis champion and an Asian Games silver medallist, found herself on the phone asking federations to send her plans and budgets or waiting in the smelly corridors of Delhi's Nehru Stadium for an audience with a federation secretary. "I wouldn't say I'm the most popular person around," she laughs. Faced by deafening silence and inactivity, the trust changed its tack in its second year and went to the athletes directly with the magic words: "Tell me what you want."

Through Mittal Steel based in Kazakhstan, the mcr located Kanat Zhaxybaev, one of the world's best coaches, and sent Indian boxers over for a short training stint before the world championships in Chicago. The true judgement on the mcr's effectiveness though will come, Malhotra says, "from the results". Every Monday she sends in a report to Amit Bhatia, Mittal's son-in-law and the mcr spearhead.

The oco, set up in 2001, is a private non-profit organisation made up of ex-athletes and business heads with two clear goals: identifying talent and raising funds. All for that irresistible idea—finding India's first individual Olympic gold medallist. The oco has signed up shooter Narang and junior 800-m runner Tintu Luka, a product of the P.T. Usha School of Athletics. Sethi and Padukone have been involved from the first day, and work with a oco board comprising R. Ramraj, co-founder of Sify, investment banker Shitin Desai and merchant banker Rakesh Khanna.

Sethi says, "The sheer emotion behind that gold medal is a powerful one. All kinds of people respond to it." In Shillong, fellow players came up to Sethi and pushed cheques for Rs 2,000 into his hands. In early July, a stranger called Ashish Kacholia grilled Sethi on the phone about how the oco's functioned. A few



## Boxing

### AKHIL KUMAR, 27

Gold medallist from the 2006 Commonwealth Games, the maverick made a dramatic comeback from injury to qualify for Beijing. The 54 kg fighter leads the largest Indian team at the Olympic Games.

**"It will take one boxer to break our medal barrier at the Olympics."**